



KEY

- Area of Shang influence
- Shang city

Shang China

The middle course of the Yellow River was the heartland of the Shang civilization c. 1800–1100 BCE. From here, Shang influence, such as bronze-working, spread elsewhere.

platform of compressed earth. They have also unearthed bronze vessels. Evidence suggests that many features that were to characterize Chinese society later, such as a strong **bureaucracy** and the **worship of ancestors**, date back to this time.

In southern Asia, the **Indus civilization**, which had thrived during the 3rd millennium (see 2500–2350 BCE), went into a **decline** by around 1800 BCE. Scholars believe that this was partly caused by the changes in the regimes of the rivers that provided water for irrigation. Cities seem to have been **ravaged by diseases** such as cholera and malaria. Trade with Mesopotamia also declined. Meanwhile, new crops such as millet and rice were introduced. All these factors seem to have led to a **decline in urban culture**, characterized by writing and a centralized bureaucracy, in favor of a **rural-based culture**.

In South America, large-scale cultivation was taking place along the Pacific coast by about 1800 BCE. Substantial settlements such as **El Paraíso** and **Sechin Alto** in Peru were dominated by **massive temple complexes**.



Long-distance trade routes linked coastal towns with communities in Andean valleys to the east and beyond. This allowed for the **spread of pottery** from Colombia to Peru by 1800 BCE. Meanwhile, in North America, crops such as sunflowers and gourds began to be cultivated in the east.

In Western Asia, the fall of the Ur III Empire led to the **rise of** two states—**Assyria** in the north and **Babylon** in the southeast—which were to dominate Mesopotamia for the next 1,500 years. The first dynasty of Babylon was established

in c. 1894 BCE. In the north, the city of **Ashur** became an important trading center in the 20th century BCE. In 1813 BCE, it was taken over by the Amorite king **Shamshi-Adad**, who **carved out a kingdom** in northern Mesopotamia. This kingdom was a forerunner of the **Greater Assyrian Empire** of the 9th century BCE (see 900–800 BCE).

Clay tablets recovered from Mari in central Mesopotamia hold records of trade and tributes levied by Assyria from vassal-states. Writing from this period included copies of the earliest surviving work of literature, *The Epic of Gilgamesh*.



Sumerian hero

Tablets and stone carvings from the Old Babylonian period provide a record of the Epic of Gilgamesh, previously passed down in the oral tradition.

“IF A MAN PUTS OUT THE EYE OF AN EQUAL, HIS EYE SHALL BE PUT OUT.”

Law Code of Hammurabi, king of Babylon

WHEN THE ASSYRIAN KING

SHAMSHI-ADAD died in 1781 BCE, he was succeeded by his son Ishme-Dagan. During his reign, **Assyria declined**, allowing the state of Babylon to come to the fore. During the reign of Shamshi-Adad, Babylon was probably a vassal state of Assyria, but as Assyria declined, **King Hammurabi** of Babylon saw his chance to seize a wider kingdom. From 1760 BCE, Hammurabi embarked on a series of conquests, which made

Babylon the region's foremost state. Between 1763–1762 BCE, he defeated Elam to the east and Larsa, which controlled Sumer, to the south. In 1757–1755 BCE, King Hammurabi conquered much of northern Mesopotamia and took the city of Eshnunna after diverting its water supply.

Hammurabi introduced the Babylonian law code in the region under his control. Its 282 laws covered property, family, trade, and business practices. The **Law Code of Hammurabi** is famous for punitive laws that meted out punishments in the same

measure as the crime committed (“an eye for an eye”). However, it is thought that the law code was more of a moral statement of principle than an enforced judicial system. As such, the code bound the powerful and wealthy as well as ordinary people; the strong were exhorted to refrain from oppressing the weak.



Set in stone

Hammurabi's code was inscribed on stone pillars called **stele**. This stele shows the god of justice Shamash (left) dictating laws to the king.

c. 1800 BCE Shang civilization begins in China

c. 1800 BCE Ceremonial center of La Florida built in Peru

1792–1750 BCE Reign of Hammurabi of Babylon; establishes Babylonian Empire in Mesopotamia and promulgates a legal code for use throughout his empire

1766 BCE Traditional date for founding of Shang dynasty by King Tang, according to Chinese history

c. 1750 BCE Linear A script comes into use in Crete

c. 1750 BCE Large ceremonial complex of Sechin Alto constructed in Peru

c. 1725 BCE Middle Kingdom in Egypt torn by unrest; start of Second Intermediate Period (to c. 1540 BCE)